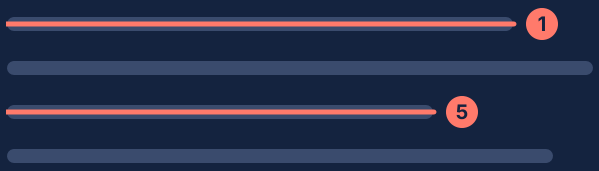
Admitted



A free guide for college applicants

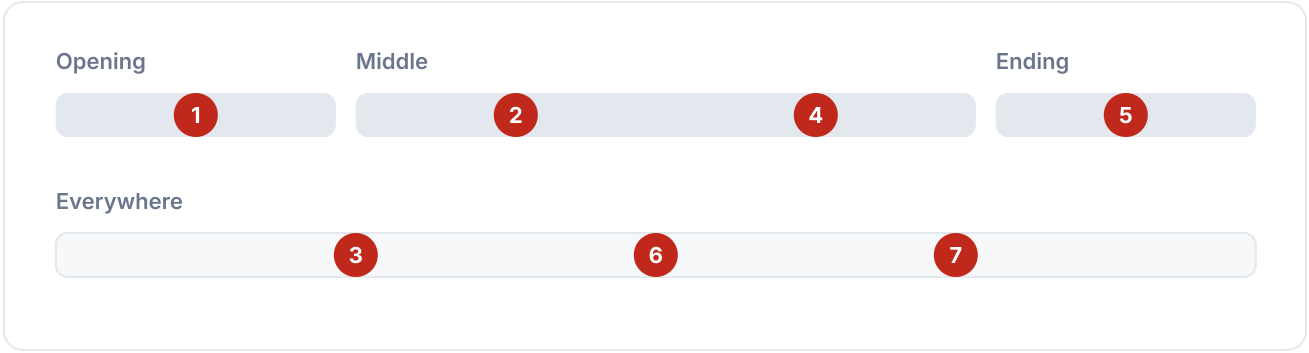
The 7 mistakes that sink college essays.

What they look like, why admissions readers stop reading, and how to fix each one before you submit.

Where they hide

Seven mistakes, and where each one shows up.

Your grades already told readers what you've done. The essay is where they hear how you think, and these seven are why most drafts don't get heard.



1	**The borrowed opening**	A quote, a definition, "ever since I was young"	p. 3
2	**The résumé in paragraphs**	Every activity, none of them deep	p. 3
3	**Claims with no proof**	"Hardworking", "passionate", never shown	p. 4
4	**Nothing changes**	A story with no turn	p. 4
5	**The announced lesson**	"This taught me..." and a promise to succeed	p. 5
6	**The thesaurus voice**	Words you'd never say out loud	p. 5
7	**Answering a different question**	A supplement that fits any school	p. 5

Notice what isn't on the list: a boring topic. A Saturday job can carry an essay further than a tragedy. Readers forgive an ordinary subject. They don't forgive these.

The opening and the middle

Mistakes 1 and 2.

01 The borrowed opening

A famous quote, a dictionary definition, "ever since I was young". The first line is where a reader decides how closely to read the rest, and this one tells them you're about to say what everyone says.

Sinks it

Ever since I was young, I have been passionate about helping others. As Gandhi said, "Be the change you wish to see in the world."

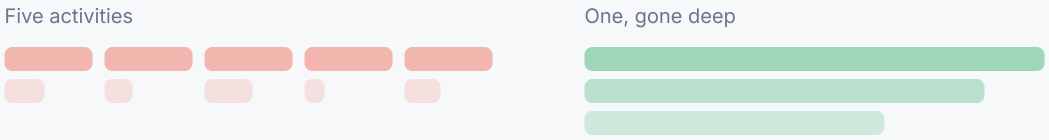
Fixes it

The left boot always comes in worse. Mrs. Alvarez drags that foot a little, and the heel wears to a slant you can feel with your thumb.

The fix: cut your first paragraph. Start where the story actually starts, inside one moment.

02 The résumé in paragraphs

Club, captain, volunteer, award, each with a sentence. Your activities list already did this, and better. Five things said briefly leave the reader knowing nothing new about any of them.



Same word count. The left says what you did. The right shows who you are.

Sinks it

As captain of the debate team, president of Key Club and a hospital volunteer, I learned leadership in many settings.

Fixes it

The patient in 4B asked me the same question every Tuesday, and every Tuesday I answered it as if it were new.

The fix: pick the one experience you could talk about for an hour. Cut the rest from the essay.

Everywhere and the middle

Mistakes 3 and 4.

03 Claims with no proof

"I'm hardworking." "I'm passionate about science." A claim asks the reader to trust you. A detail lets them see it. Every sentence about yourself sits somewhere on this ladder.

Claim	"I am a hardworking and responsible person."
General	"I worked hard at my grandfather's shop after his stroke."
Proof	"I ruined two soles that April and paid for them out of my own envelope, which he noticed and did not mention."

The fix: find every adjective you use about yourself. Replace it with the moment that proves it, or cut it.

04 Nothing changes

The essay describes something that happened, and you end it the same person you started. Readers are looking for the turn: the point where what you believed stopped being true, or got more complicated.



The fix: finish this sentence: "I used to think ___. Now I ___." If you can't, the essay doesn't have a turn yet.

The ending and everywhere

Mistakes 5, 6 and 7.

05 The announced lesson

The last paragraph restates the moral and predicts your success. It's the most common ending there is, which is why it could end anyone's essay.

Sinks it	Fixes it
This experience taught me the value of hard work, and I know these skills will help me succeed in college and beyond.	"Show me on the other one first," she said, and put her foot up on the bench.

The fix: delete your last two sentences. End on an action or an image, one line earlier than feels safe.

06 The thesaurus voice

"Myriad", "invaluable", "plethora". Words you'd never say out loud make you sound like someone else, and readers came to hear you.

Sinks it	Fixes it
This multifaceted endeavor afforded me invaluable insight into a myriad of perspectives.	I found out most people at the shelter had jobs.

The fix: read it aloud. Rewrite every line you wouldn't say to a teacher you respect.

07 Answering a different question

Mostly a supplement problem. A "why us" essay that would work with any school's name swapped in, or a prompt answered only in the last line.

Sinks it	Fixes it
I'm drawn to your world-class faculty, diverse community and beautiful campus.	I want to bring the shoe-shop ledger to Professor Lin's small-business lab.

The fix: swap in a rival's name. If it still works, name a class or program only this school has.

Before you submit

Seven checks, one per mistake.

Print this page. Tick each one, or fix it.

- [ ] **1** My first sentence puts the reader inside one moment.
  No quote, no definition, no "ever since".

- [ ] **2** The essay is about one experience, not a tour of my activities.
  Anything already on my activities list is cut or one line.

- [ ] **3** Every adjective about myself is proven by a detail, or gone.
  "Hardworking", "passionate", "dedicated": find them and check.

- [ ] **4** I can underline the sentence where something I believed changed.
  "I used to think ___. Now I ___."

- [ ] **5** My last line doesn't state the lesson or predict my success.
  It ends on an action or an image.

- [ ] **6** I read it aloud and it sounds like me.
  No word I'd never say out loud.

- [ ] **7** With a rival school's name swapped in, it stops working.
  And it answers the prompt the whole way through, under the word limit.



Ticked all seven? Have someone who doesn't know the story read it. Ask them one question: "What do you think I care about?" If their answer isn't yours, go back to mistake 3.

The hard part

You won't catch these in your own draft.

You know what you meant, so you read the missing detail back in.
You've read your opening forty times, so it stops sounding borrowed.
That's why the mistakes survive to the final draft.

Admitted essay review Example

Ever since I was young, I have been passionate about helping others. I started volunteering at the food bank in ninth grade. This experience taught me the value of hard work.

Mistake 1 · the borrowed opening

The reader learns the moral before the story. Start inside one shift instead.

A question only you can answer

What's one thing someone said to you at the food bank that you still remember?

Rated

Your draft scored on what readers look for.

Flagged

The exact lines that fall into these seven.

Rewritten

From your details, in your voice.

Find the mistakes in your essay.

Admitted is an AI tool that rates and improves college essays. $9.99 a week, cancel anytime.

admitted.usetrnd.com/essay